1949, a period of twelve years which, by the purest coincidence, covered that portion of my writing career that preceded my first book, Astounding was the only science-fiction magazine that counted. Other magazines were all fringe operations designed to publish stories that Campbell found not good enough or that authors knew in advance he would not even look at.

But then, with the new decade of the 1950s, new magazines appeared that were to rival Astounding. Campbell continued to be important but he would no longer be a lonely giant. He would have competitors.

The first of these new magazines was The Magazine of Fantasy and Science Fiction (usually referred to as F 6 SF), edited by Anthony Boucher and J. Francis McComas. It began as a quarterly, and I picked up my first copy on January 24, 1950.

There were signs of inflation. The science-fiction magazines, which

used to be twenty cents an issue or less, had by now advanced to twenty-five cents, and F & SF was thirty-five cents.

On January 29, the New York Times finally reviewed Pebble in the Sky y a review that ended with, "Mr. Asimov is an old hand at this sort of thing and this novel makes for fine reading." I was satisfied, especially since both Sprague and Bob Heinlein wrote to tell me how much they liked the book.

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The next day the teaching semester started and I was sick—a cold had developed into laryngitis. I went around for a week, practicing the phrase, "Today we take up simple lipids" to check on how my voice was progressing, till Gertrude said that she had never grown so tired of a particular sentence in her whole life.

Even before I gave my lecture, of course, I had to carry my weight in the biochemistry laboratory. The first session of the lab was held on January 31, 1950, and I stood there in my white lab coat feeling very superior and professorial with all the students deferentially calling me "Doctor."

Then one student came over and with no trace of wise-guyishness at all, said, "Pardon me, Dr. Asimov, are you a Ph.D. or a real doctor?"

It put me in my place. A Ph.D. is the highest academic degree there is, and is awarded only for original research. An M.D., on the contrary, is given out on